

together
we are

GREATER
MANCHESTER

Shaping How We Live Well Together

A Greater Manchester Participation Playbook



Commissioned through GM Live Well, Greater Manchester's public services, voluntary sector and communities working together to develop everyday support in every neighbourhood.



Shaping How We Live Well Together

A Greater Manchester Participation Playbook

Where residents and public services work side by side to make Greater Manchester a healthy and happy place for everyone.

Now is the time to press play on participation.

Right now, people across our city region are feeling the pain of deepening inequalities, and services are struggling to meet rising needs. Public trust is falling, and participation in traditional democratic processes – like voting – has reached historic lows. For too long, decisions have been made *about* people, not *with* them. Power can feel distant, disconnected, and out of reach.

That's why we're pressing play on a new way of doing things in Greater Manchester: one where decisions are made *by* the people, for the people – where community power and participatory democracy thrive.

This Playbook is for anyone asking: How do we face today's biggest challenges, and how do we do it together?

It's for those who want to rebuild trust, shift power closer to communities, and find practical ways to involve residents in shaping the decisions that affect their lives.

Whether you're a resident, policymaker, charity leader, or community organiser, there's something in the Participation Playbook for you. We all have a role in making Greater Manchester a great place to live – and we can all take action to get there together.

What's more, it's already happening. This Playbook showcases a variety of accessible, effective, and engaging tools for participatory decision-making, budgeting, and co-production – all tried and tested by our communities, leading to powerful outcomes.

Communities hold strength, knowledge, and creativity, and these should shape decisions at every level: in our health services, schools, community groups, housing associations,



“
*Ask us, as communities
have the solutions.*”

THE ELEPHANTS TRAIL

councils, and across all public services. When people are truly listened to and involved, our neighbourhoods, cities, and democracy grow stronger.

This Playbook celebrates the power of working together to design and deliver solutions that matter. Real change happens when we shift how we work-building a culture where participation is at the heart of everything we do. Whether we're sharing information, inviting ideas, or co-creating solutions, every interaction should start with a spirit of openness and collaboration.

Across Greater Manchester, the strengths, stories, and experiences of our people and places are our greatest asset. Every conversation, every connection, every local insight helps shape better support and services for everyday life. By listening to each other and working side by side, we can create a fairer, healthier Greater Manchester where everyone has the chance to live well.

Community leadership and collective action run deep in Greater Manchester's story – from the Rochdale Pioneers to the reformers and suffragettes, to the Manchester cotton workers who refused slave-picked cotton. Our region-wide commitment to community power and participatory democracy builds on that legacy.



When **power** is devolved not just to regions but to **people**, it can **transform lives** and **rebuild trust** in politics. When you **trust people**, they rise to the challenge.

Time and again, we've seen it across this city-region – people stepping forward, **pulling together**, and making a difference. The **pride people feel** in our neighbourhoods, our towns, and our communities is what makes us **strong** and **resilient**, and keeps us going when times are tough.

If we open up **decision-making**, we can **transform lives**, rebuild **trust** in politics, and create a **fairer, healthier** Greater Manchester where everyone has the **chance** to **live well**.

ANDY BURNHAM

MAYOR OF GREATER MANCHESTER



Rules of the Game:

How to Use this Playbook



- 1 Browse** through the tools, read about these practices in action in Greater Manchester, and spot your neighbours in the pictures!
- 2 Gather** your colleagues and neighbours, share your excitement, and **talk** about upcoming decisions that would benefit from more participation and which tools could work best.
- 3 Test** out one of these tools: **press play!** You can use just one participatory process or combine a few to suit your needs. You can also start with everyday tools to warm up.
- 4 Get help** from the resources guide (see page 28 to scan QR code), which includes links to free toolkits and step-by-step guides, plus a directory of local practitioners who can help design and run processes.
- 5 Return** to the Playbook again and again, using it as both a guide and a source of inspiration, and **share** your discoveries with the #GMLiveWell movement.
- 6 Invent** your own participatory processes.

Community-led decision-making works best when it's shaped by the people it serves and tailored to the opportunities at hand.

You've got this!



Inside the Playbook

Core Values of Participation	5
Participatory Budgeting	6
Participatory Grantmaking	8
Citizens' Assemblies and Juries	10
Legislative Theatre	12
Digital Democracy	14
Participatory Design	16
Community Reporting and Evaluation	18
Tools for getting Conversations Going	20
Making it Happen	22
What's in the Game Box?	23
Who are the Key Players?	24
Press Play on your Participatory Process!	26
Glossary (in Poetry)	28



Credits

Coordinated by

Katy Rubin of The People Act: Legislative Theatre, and Liz Mytton of Theatre In Flow.

Participatory Democracy

Writing Committee

Jez Hall, Caroline Tosal-Suprun, Kyle Soo, Patrick Tierney, Liz Mytton, and Katy Rubin.

With special thanks to Hannah Paterson, Reka Polonyi, John Organ, Helen Davies, and Veronika Susedkova.

Design by Bruce Mytton.

Illustrated by James Neville.

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Contributor Details

Katy Rubin is a Creative Civic Strategist and Director of The People Act: Legislative Theatre.

Liz Mytton is a Coach and Creative Director at Theatre In Flow.

Patrick Tierney is an Engagement Worker at The Elephants Trail Project.

Jez Hall is a Director at Shared Future CIC and specialist in Participatory Budgeting.

Caroline Tosal-Suprun is an Engagement and Participation Practitioner based in Bolton.

Kyle Soo is a LEGO® Serious Play Facilitator and Founder of Brickolage.

The Participation Playbook was commissioned by GM Live Well and created by a committee of participatory democracy experts, practitioners and community members, all based in Greater Manchester (GM). GM Live Well is part of the Greater Manchester Strategy – Greater Manchester's commitment to ensuring great everyday support is available in every neighbourhood. Together, communities, public services and partners can tackle health, social and economic inequalities by changing how we work with each other to grow opportunities for everyone to Live Well.

Core Values of Participation:

Shaping How We Live Well Together

In this Playbook...

...you'll find a collection of **participatory tools** and methods that can **support communities** and decision-makers to **work collaboratively**, shaping how we live well together. **Co-production** is at the centre of all participatory practices. It describes working in partnership by sharing **power between people**. It can take many shapes, but at the core, it brings together **decision-makers** and **community members** with **lived experience** to shift **policy** and spark **systems change**. Relationship-building, communication, and equitable processes are all key ingredients. **Co-production** is particularly important on issues where those directly impacted by the problem have historically been excluded.

The **Jam and Justice** principles for co-production, developed by a collective in Greater Manchester, place equality, shared power, and respect at the heart of every decision. **These are:**



1 Co-Production is more than consultation

- Involve people with lived experience from the very start through to the end of a project.
- Build genuine partnerships where everyone has influence, not just a chance to give feedback.

2 Share power and responsibility

- Share ownership of the process and the outcomes.
- Be transparent about what decisions are open to change.

3 Value lived experience

- Treat lived experience as expertise, alongside professional or technical knowledge.

4 Start with strengths

- Take an asset-based approach: focus on skills, knowledge, and resources already in the community.
- Build on what's working well instead of only trying to "fix" problems.

5 Honour diversity and inclusion

- Remove barriers to participation (for example, provide translation, childcare, transport, payment and expenses, accessible venues or tools).
- Recognise both shared experiences and differences in identity, culture, and perspective.

6 Stay flexible – no one-size-fits-all

- Adapt your approach to suit the people, place, and context.
- Keep plans open and responsive to new ideas as they emerge.

7 Build trust and capacity

- Allow time for relationships to grow before diving into decisions.
- Support participants to develop the skills, confidence, and tools they need to take part fully.

8 Use the right tools – including digital

- Use online platforms where they can make participation easier or reach more people.
- Choose tools that are accessible and that match the needs of the group.

9 Face challenges openly

- Recognise that including diverse voices and incentivising participation can take time and resources.
- Keep these challenges in the open and work together to address them.

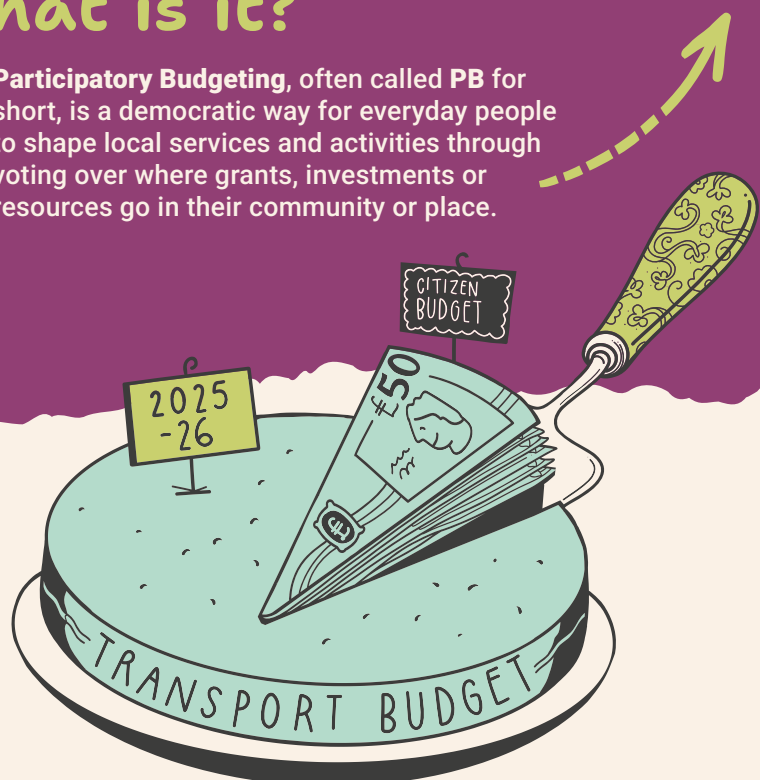
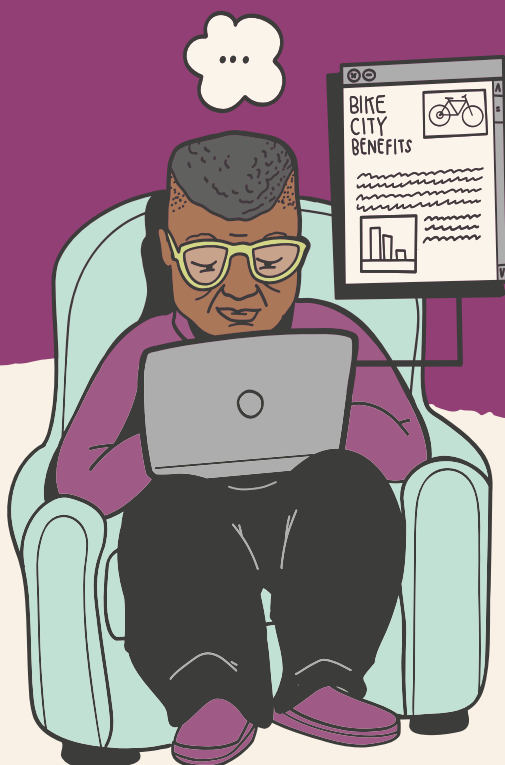


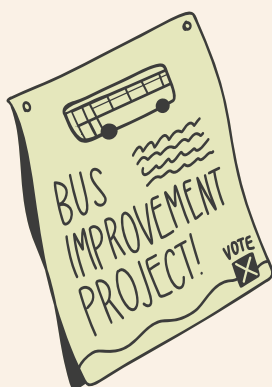


Participatory Budgeting

What is it?

Participatory Budgeting, often called **PB** for short, is a democratic way for everyday people to shape local services and activities through voting over where grants, investments or resources go in their community or place.





How does it work?

Participatory Budgeting generally involves several steps:

Propose: Community members prioritise what matters and suggest solutions, which are turned into actual project proposals. Projects might be delivered by community members, or by the organisations that support them.

Share: The projects, always with a budget attached, are shared with the whole community, who are invited to have their say.

Decide: A public vote is held, with community members individually choosing a number of projects that they think best address unmet needs in their community. The decision can be made face to face at an event or can be held online for larger processes.

Deliver: The money goes to those delivering the chosen projects, who later feed back on what was achieved. Ideally another round of PB then happens, and learning grows over time about what works and a community's priorities.



When is it useful?

When you are looking to really shift power. By focusing on budgets, you move beyond having conversations to actually making a difference. It's like a community-led commissioning process.



Local Examples

In 2025, Young Manchester supported **Choose for Cheetham**, a £200,000 PB programme. Over 100 young people, as well as organisations responsible for the projects on the ballot, were able to vote. The youth vote was the most important in making the decision, but it was also valuable to bring the organisations supporting young people in Cheetham Hill together. The voting events were joyful, informative and empowering.



“

I turned up today because I want to make a change.”

YOUNG PERSON AT
CHOOSE FOR CHEETHAM

In 2025, COMMUNITY Little Hulton launched community voting. £65,000 was available for the community to spend to improve the health and wellbeing of people living in Little Hulton.





Participatory Grantmaking

What is it?

Participatory grantmaking (or **PGM** for short) is a way of sharing power in grant making. This means decisions are made in a non-hierarchical and flexible manner – including decisions about strategy, eligibility, funding offers, measuring impact and sharing learning.

Local Examples

In early 2023, 22 grassroots organisations from across Greater Manchester, all part of the **GM Systems Changers** network, were invited to design and decide how a £400,000 fund – jointly supported by **Lankelly Chase** and the **Greater Manchester Combined Authority** – would be spent.

The process began with members co-designing how they would work together and make collective decisions. Through this participatory approach, funding was allocated to a diverse range of projects that nurtured spaces of solidarity and spaces of liberation, focused on equity and tackling structural discrimination. These included initiatives led by and for young people, disabled communities, LGBTQ+ groups, and racial justice projects, as well as strengthening the **GM Systems Changers** network to drive lasting systems change.



“

The collaborative environment, insightful discussions and opportunities for learning have been incredibly enriching. I have gained valuable insights that have surpassed what I anticipated when joining the group.”

GM SYSTEMS CHANGER

How does it work?

PGM can work in many ways depending on the context and community it is supporting. Each PGM process should involve a decision-making collective which includes local residents or people who will be impacted by the grant funds; together, they make the decisions about how grant funding should be spent.

There are lots of different types of decisions to be made, such as:

- What the funding is aiming to achieve.
- What types of things can be funded.
- Who is eligible to apply.
- How people apply or are chosen to apply to the funding.
- Which people or organisations receive a grant.
- What we want to learn about and how we go about learning about it.

And there are lots of different ways these decisions can be made:

- Consensus-based: discussions or workshops until everyone agrees.
- A vote.
- A community panel.
- Those who have applied for the funding make the decision together.
- Funders and community members working together.
- Only community members make the decisions.



When is it useful?

PGM can be useful in many settings, including:

- Increasing funding to excluded and underfunded communities.
- Strengthening the knowledge and decisions made by traditional funders.
- When funders don't know the local context of a community they want to support.
- When trust is low between communities and funders.
- Building power in a particular sector or community through collaboration, peer support and honest dialogue.

Citizens' Assemblies and Juries



What is it?

A deliberative process in which a group of residents consider an issue over a period of time to create a set of recommendations. A citizens' assembly typically involves 50+ randomly selected people to reflect the wider population. A citizens' jury, also called a 'mini public,' uses the same process but with fewer people, usually involving 12–30 people.

How does it work?

Four key phases follow the planning and recruitment of participants:

- 1 Learning:** Participants learn from one another and from people with in-depth knowledge of the issue.
- 2 Deliberating:** With facilitator support, the group debates, reflects, and analyses evidence and perspectives.
- 3 Decision Making:** The group develops a set of recommendations for decision makers to consider.
- 4 Implementation:** In the best case scenario, decision-makers follow the assembly's recommendations and commit to an implementation plan and timeframe.

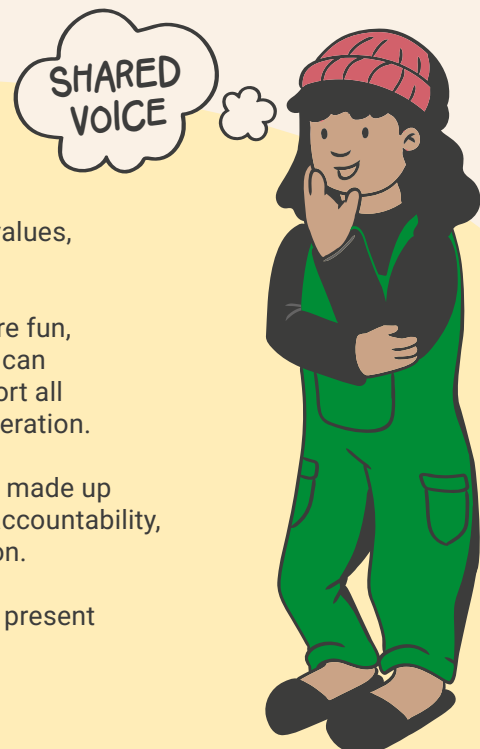
The process is built on these principles

Representation: A cross-section of society brings diverse values, knowledge, and experiences.

Structure and equity: Skilled facilitators ensure sessions are fun, inclusive, engaging, and accessible for all so that everyone can participate and feel good in doing so. The facilitators support all participants in the process and guide the framing and deliberation.

Transparency and governance: An oversight group, usually made up of people with insight and influence on the issue, ensures accountability, suggests information sources, and supports implementation.

Knowledge and expertise: Experts (both lived and learned) present evidence, ideas, perspectives and answer questions.





When is it useful?

Ideal for any issue that requires broad input but particularly useful when considering complex, emotive, contentious, or high-impact issues. The process often ends with energised and enthusiastic groups of community members who want to be part of the solution.

Local Examples

In 2019, Tonge with the Haulgh Big Local Partnership (TwthBLP) in Bolton aimed to involve young people in decision-making and commissioned **Creative City** to lead an assembly-style process with local youth. Over 12 weeks, young participants played games, met stakeholders, and developed 24 recommendations. Impressed by the outcome, TwthBLP handed over the youth budget to the group, leading to a participatory budgeting process the following year.



In 2022, 12 Greater Manchester residents met over six sessions to explore and make recommendations on a governance model for the local energy market. This process was delivered by **Carbon Coop** as part of a wider effort to ensure greater transparency and accountability around this issue, to meet the energy needs of all residents. These local recommendations influenced the public engagement built into the Regional Energy System Planner and were shared with national bodies such as Ofgem and Department for Energy Security and Net Zero.



Legislative Theatre



What is it?

Legislative Theatre (or **LT** for short) is a creative participatory policymaking and service design tool. It brings residents and policymakers together to co-create innovative solutions to complex challenges. It's accessible, engaging, and fun.



How does it work?

Watch: Community members create and perform original plays based on lived experiences and research, addressing local or national policy challenges.

Act: Audience members step onstage to improvise alternatives, testing new rules and policies in real time.

Propose: Audiences, advocates and policymakers collaboratively shape these ideas into policy proposals, followed by deliberation and amendments.

Vote: Everyone votes on the proposals, and policymakers make commitments to action.

When is it useful?

When directly impacted groups have been historically excluded from decision-making; stakeholders are looking for creative solutions; or an issue is tense or polarising.

Local Examples

In 2023, GM Moving and Trafford Council commissioned a legislative theatre process on public safety for women and girls, called *Right to the Streets*. The play illuminated how women avoid public transport and outdoor exercise due to harassment, assault and unsafe spaces.

The process delivered concrete policy impacts, including: all transport staff received active bystander training; a widespread communications campaign on trams and buses against gendered harassment; and young participants taking on official advisory roles in regional government.

“

*I've had so many instances when I've felt unsafe, and that's why *Right to the Streets* is so important to me. For people to be able to interact with characters, rather than just seeing data and statistics – it's important to feel it. Democracy should be fun!*

”

LEGISLATIVE THEATRE
COMMUNITY ACTOR

In 2020, Greater Manchester Combined Authority commissioned a LT process to create **Greater Manchester's five-year homelessness prevention strategy**. The project included 35 actors with experience of homelessness and hundreds of audience members and policymakers.

Twenty three proposals were incorporated into the Strategy, leading to changes including: management-level roles for people with lived experience across the region; lived experience-led, trauma-informed training programmes; and ongoing co-production in development of action plans and strategy evaluations.



Digital Democracy



What is it?

Digital Democracy is the use of digital tools and technology to make democratic participation more accessible, inclusive, and transparent. It enables people to learn, discuss, and influence decisions online, from voting and consultations to participatory budgeting and policy co-creation.

Local Examples



In 2024, the NHS launched a national digital democracy initiative, **Change NHS**. The project aimed to inform the government's 10-year health plan, to 'build a health service fit for the future.' Over eight months, a digital platform engaged thousands of staff and members of the public,

with 250,000 ideas submitted. Engagement with the platform was amplified by in-person workshops and summits. Recommendations related to difficulty getting appointments, long wait times in A&E, and a lack of joined-up care; all contributions fed into the 10-Year Health Plan.

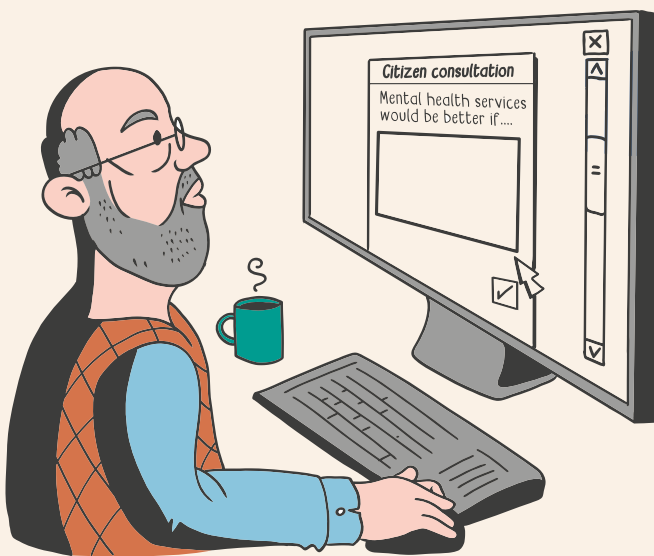
How does it work?

Digital platforms allow residents to participate in collective activities like proposing projects, planning how to use public spaces, voting on public spending, and drafting and deliberating on legislation.

These platforms can also be used for tracking and monitoring a participatory process and can support other tools like citizens' assemblies.



“These platforms can help communities and decision-makers carry out these steps in transparent, secure, and fun ways.”



When is it useful?

When seeking to expand the reach of an in-person process, including residents who are otherwise excluded due to mobility and transport or caring responsibilities. Although specialised platforms are useful, free resources like Google forms can serve a similar purpose.

All of these tools must be applied carefully to ensure they don't present further barriers, due to lack of access to devices, internet or digital literacy. Processes involving digital democracy should incorporate training and in-person support, to ensure the widest-possible participation.

“Pol.is really added a level of credibility to the whole process.”

LANCASTER PARTICIPANT

In 2023, the **Local Climate Engagement** programme led by Shared Future CIC and Lancaster City Council combined various participatory methods to increase public engagement in climate policy. First, they used a digital tool called **Pol.is** to gather opinions on the question: “How can we lead a good life by moving around freely

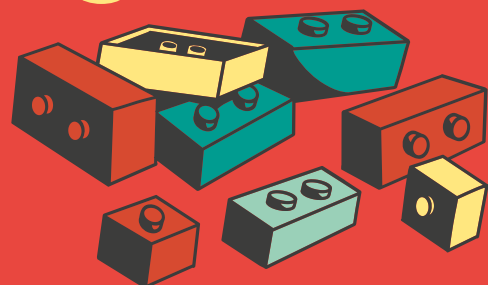
and at the same time reducing emissions?”. Residents were able to share personal viewpoints online, and vote to ‘agree’ or ‘disagree’ with others. Over 520 residents submitted ideas, with over 41,000 unique votes recorded. The findings were used in follow-on deliberative workshops to inform recommendations for change.



Participatory Design

What is it?

Participatory Design centres the experience and knowledge of community members using creative and playful tools and methods to shape ideas and solutions together. It can be used in many contexts, but is especially valuable when designing new services, initiatives and programmes.



Local Examples

Wigan Borough Community First used LEGO® Serious Play to engage with the voluntary, community, faith and social enterprise sector to co-create a new local infrastructure organisation.

This creative approach enabled 120 attendees to explore and share ideas for the sector, touching on key themes of accountability, decision-making and co-design. The hands-on method unlocked new ways of thinking and expressing complex issues, allowing participants to contribute authentically and collaboratively whilst fostering creativity and teamwork.



“

I enjoyed the freedom of expression using the LEGO®. It made me think more about how issues can be represented and resolved. ”

How does it work?

Participatory Design uses a variety of tools and methods, often from the work of design-thinking*, to engage with residents and organisations in imaginative ways to share their stories and experiences. For example, using:

- Tools like stakeholder maps and frameworks to help visualise connections and relationships.
- LEGO® Serious Play, where participants build LEGO® models to help share their stories and ideas on a topic in small groups.
- Liberating Structures methods – simple rules that make it possible to involve every voice. These include a set of recipes for running innovation sessions that build connections and relationships between participants.
- Method cards – physical prompt cards that help stimulate ideas with participants.

**Design thinking is a human-centred, practical approach to creating better solutions.*



When is it useful?

When creating anything to be used by people. Working with community members affected by a service or programme provides insights into their lived experience, tests assumptions, surfaces unforeseen issues, and helps to ensure stronger buy-in while managing expectations.

Using creative tools allows ideas to be explored in imaginative ways, making it especially valuable for generating new insights.



Community Reporting and Evaluation



What is it?

In **community reporting** and evaluation, community journalists highlight issues that are meaningful to people whose voices are rarely heard, in order to inform decisions or measure the impact of public programmes.

This ensures that people's stories and experiences are directly represented in decision-making spaces and that issues are communicated on an emotional level as well as through data.





When is it useful?

Ideal for raising awareness, developing solidarity and championing the idea that the people who are closest to the issues are best placed to explore those issues publicly.

It is most useful when a community can offer a more direct perspective than external journalists or evaluators, when designing or reviewing programs, highlighting community assets or changing narratives.

How does it work?

Community reporting equips local people with the skills to tell their own stories through different media, such as print, audio, and video. This is sometimes co-produced with a professional journalist. For some readers or viewers, these stories offer a window into places they might not easily access otherwise and can include a call to action.



Local Examples

The **Elephants Trail** community reporting team, based in Rochdale, has co-produced videos with The Guardian for its Made in Britain series, reframing the conversation about employment, mental health, immigration, and local elections. These films, and others created to showcase the Live Well movement, have been shown to large audiences and decision-makers to inspire strategic documents, inform spending bids and train people working in public services.



“

People are really open with me, so I'm finding people sharing things with me that they would not share with someone from the council. So, this community engagement via somebody like myself, somebody with lived experience, is vital.

MEMBER OF THE ELEPHANTS TRAIL

”

Tools for getting Conversations Going



Deep Democracy

Deep Democracy is a facilitated approach for a group to explore and address tensions, or polarised views, around a difficult topic. It guides people through tricky conversations, aiming to shift perspectives through empathy and collaboration. The approach focuses on welcoming dissenting opinions and tapping into the 'wisdom of the minority', to lead to more inclusive outcomes.

Deep Democracy has been applied in practice to a range of issues, such as homelessness in Greater Manchester and Health Inequalities support in Rochdale.

Long Table

A Long Table is a simple and accessible tool for discussion, in the style of a dinner party, to bring some theatricality to public engagement. There are 12 chairs around the table, which is surrounded by a wider circle of chairs for participants, who can take turns to come up to the table to write on the tablecloth or speak publicly.

Long Tables have been run in Greater Manchester on a variety of themes including reducing violence against women and girls, access to dental care, poverty, sustainability and homelessness.

YOUR
TURN

SPEAK UP!

World Cafe

World Cafe uses the ambiance of a cafe set-up to encourage conversation around multiple tables, all themes based on the issue at hand. Participants can start by joining a conversation at one table on a specific theme and then move between different tables and contribute to different conversations, building upon what's already been said. The structure promotes open dialogue between a range of community members in a relaxed setting.

Exercises to encourage inclusive and creative environments

Warm-up games and exercises can support groups to build community, break down hierarchies in the space and get creative.

The following examples are just a few of many options and only take 10 – 15 minutes.



The Opposites Game

To have fun and encourage out-of-the-box thinking.

1. Demonstration:

- Tell the group to walk (or move in their seat) when you say **"move"** and stop when you say **"stop"**. Practice a few times.
- Next in this game, you will switch the meanings of words. Everyone should walk when you say **"stop"** and stop when you say **"move"**. Try it out.
- Add more pairs of words: we recommend selecting instructions that will feel fun and accessible to the group you are playing with.
 - Clap/Jump (one clap and one jump).
 - Arms/Knees (arms in the air, and touch your knees).
 - Name/Yell (say your name, and give a short yell, **"Ay!"**).

2. Debrief:

"How did that feel?" "Where did we learn these rules, and how can we unlearn and make our own rules?"

Connect the experience of the game to the lived experiences of the players. **"What else do we do every day because everyone else does, or people are told to do so?" "What rules do we want to turn upside down, like the game?"**

Image of the Word

To surface shared experiences and gather varied responses to a new or challenging idea.

1. Demonstration:

- Participants make a big circle. Say, **"When I say a word or phrase, build your body into a sculpture/ image of that word"**. After everyone has had a chance to build their sculpture, count **"one, two, three, image"**, and everyone freezes, looking around to see the other images.
- Start with warm-up words: birthday, beach, etc. Move on to themes that relate to the issue: education, health care, etc. While everyone holds their image, invite participants to shout out what they see around the circle. These can be feelings or big ideas, like **"anger"** or **"waiting for an appointment"**. Anything they see and say is valid.

2. Variation for group-building:

- Create families: Say **"While holding your image, move into a "family" – a group of other images that feel similar to yours"**. As before, each group can look at the other families of images and talk about what they see. These families can turn into story-sharing or discussion groups on a specific topic.

Making it Happen

These tools are flexible. They can be adapted for specific situations, places and budgets. While each tool is distinct, they are part of a participatory eco-system that can jointly support a range of outcomes.

For example, it is possible that a project would benefit from a **Long Table** event to surface concerns, followed by a **Legislative Theatre** process to gather proposals for new programs, concluding with a **Participatory Budgeting** process to decide on and distribute the funds.

Additionally, fair and inclusive processes need the right conditions to thrive, and that means investing the time, care and resources that communities deserve.

Every process requires a different budget, depending on the number of people involved, timescales and scope. It's generally recommended to **allocate about 5–10% of the total programme or service budget** to the participatory decision-making process, to achieve the best results. That budget may include fees for facilitators and participants; space, materials, and food; transportation; and planning and follow-up.

After an organisation has implemented a participatory process a few times, the existing staff or community members may feel prepared to lead on facilitation and design, once the methods and values have become second-nature. Participation gets easier and cheaper over time.

What's in the Game Box?

A physical space that's welcoming and accessible — and/or online tools that are easy for people to use at home.

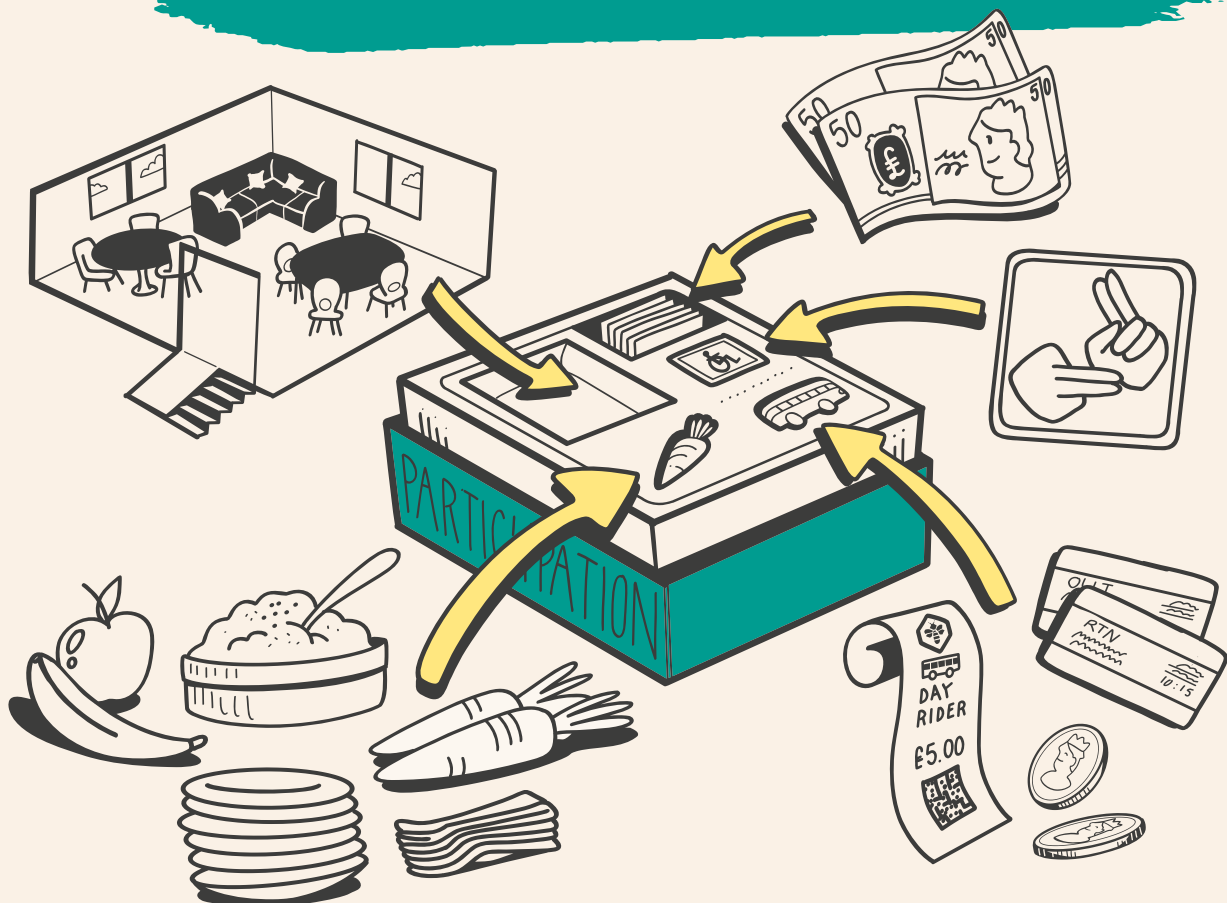
A project schedule shaped with community members, so it works for the majority.

Transport costs covered.

Food that's locally sourced and culturally appropriate.

Expenses or payments for participants where appropriate — especially for projects with a big time commitment.

Additional accessibility support where needed: translation, childcare, sign language interpreters, etc.



Who are the Key Players?

When starting a participatory process, it's important to bring together a wide range of community members and partners. Each person contributes their own life experience, knowledge, and skills – shaping the outcome and offering the best chance of success.

Equity, diversity, and inclusion must be at the heart of participatory work. Ask: ***"Whose voice isn't heard in this community?"***, ***"Who usually holds the power?"*** You'll need to invest time, effort, and resources to ensure representation is broad and meaningful. Think about who's already in your network, and who else you might need to connect with.



The Practitioner or Facilitator

This person leads processes, organises people, and makes the work happen. They thrive on structure, timelines, and action – and they'll hold it all together when things get busy.

Example: This person might be a project manager, an events coordinator, or a community arts facilitator.

The Connected Community Member

This person is rooted, vocal and present. They speak from lived experience and bring depth through their commitment to place and people. They make sure the community's voice is front and centre.

Example: This person might run a tenants' association, volunteer at a youth club or have lived experience relevant to the issue at hand.

The Enabler

This person works from inside the system to make space for change. They may be in a role that can unlock resources, shift policies or open doors. They help make things possible, even if they're not in the spotlight.

Example: This person might be a council officer, a community development worker or a funding programme manager.



Press Play on your Participatory Process!



There's no time like the present to bring this Playbook to life and embed more participation into your work. This exercise can help you begin to design and plan your participatory process. It will take 15 minutes, with four or more stakeholders...

Try it right now!



Sit down together with the key players; invested community members, decision-makers or 'enablers,' and other important stakeholders. We recommend sitting in a circle and closing your laptops for now. If you have biscuits and a brew to share, even better.

Introduce yourself, share your name and something you bring to the participation party! ***Do you make great brownies? Do you know a few warm-up games? Do you like chatting with new people?***

Now, we're ready to start designing our participatory change process.

Think of it as a board game, with multiple players who travel from the start point to the finish line. Along the way, there may be setbacks but there are also opportunities to gain help and resources.

- 1 Why are you doing this?** What are you asking of people?
- 2 What is it that you are hoping to achieve?** Where's the finish line?
 - Create a new strategy?
 - Design a new feature in the local area?
 - Decide how to spend a public budget?
- 3 Who are the 'Players?'** How many people can take part, and how can you ensure inclusivity and accessibility?
- 4 Who might be your 'Helpers?'** What resources do you have already at your disposal? Invested organisations or local facilitators? Remember, you already have all the special skills that your group brings to the party.
- 5 How are you going to do it?** What 'Tools' will you choose for the game? Participatory Budgeting? Legislative Theatre? Use one of the methodologies in this Playbook or combine a few to suit your needs.
- 6 What 'Challenges' might come up:** What could get in the way? Do you need additional funds to pay participants? A welcoming space to meet?

Now you've scoped – what now?

- 7 Where's the starting point:** What's your first step?
- 8 How long will the game take:** What's your timeline? Don't forget planning and follow-up steps!
- 9 How do you know when you've won and how do you celebrate your progress?** Tracking and sharing outcomes is crucial for transparency, trust and encouraging ongoing involvement.

After this initial design meeting, you might:

- Follow the QR code (see page 28) for more information.
- Find a practitioner in the directory.
- Speak to your colleagues, community or collaborators about your ideas.
- Reflect on the resources you currently have and what you might need to find.
- Share your story! What actions are you taking? What is exciting you? We'd love to hear from you.

Glossary

These are key approaches to make participation work:



A Asset-Based

Start with what's strong — the skills, strengths, and resources in your community — instead of focusing only on problems.

C Co-Production

Work as equals to change policies and systems: A facilitated process in which community members with lived experience and organisations share power, decisions, and responsibility.

T Transformation (or Systems Change)

Change how systems work so they respond to community priorities and create lasting improvements.

I Inclusion and Lived Experience

Make sure every voice is heard, especially those often excluded. Value the insight of lived experience.

O Open Deliberation

Take time to share, listen, and discuss different views before making decisions together.

N Neighbourhood Knowledge

Recognise that places and the people who live, work, and connect there hold unique knowledge and influence.

P Participatory Democracy

People help make the decisions that affect their lives.

O Opportunity

Create real chances for communities to influence change.

W Working Together

Collaborate between communities, councils and organisations for shared outcomes.

E Evidence from Experience

Use community knowledge alongside other data to guide policy and action.

R Rights and Responsibility

Know your rights, hold decision-makers to account, and take shared responsibility for better outcomes.

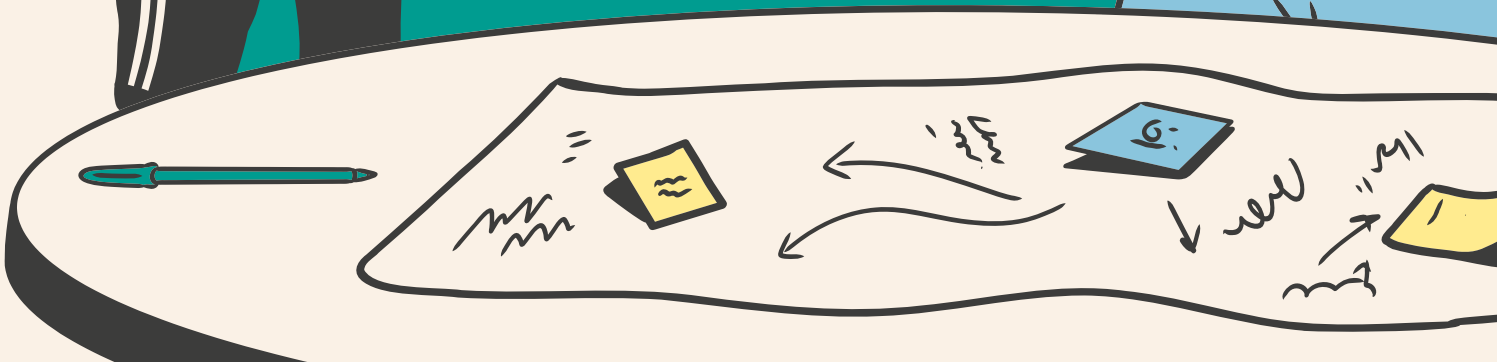


More Resources

For more resources on these participatory tools, a directory of Greater Manchester-based practitioners and more support with an upcoming initiative, visit the link below or scan the QR code.

greatermanchester-ca.gov.uk/what-we-do/live-well/live-well-resources

Share your participation practices with **#GMLiveWell**





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